



SUSTAINABILITY - 101

Major Assignment



Format: Executive Memo (Maximum 2 Pages) / Deck (Maximum 3 Slides Excluding Appendix)

Submission Deadline: End of Week 2

Situation

SnackCo is one of India's fastest-growing packaged food companies, selling chips, biscuits, and ready-to-eat snacks across the country.

Over the past five years, SnackCo has achieved rapid growth through aggressive distribution expansion and low-cost packaging solutions.

However, the company is now facing increasing pressure from multiple stakeholders:

- Environmental organizations have criticized the company for its extensive use of single-use plastic packaging.
- Consumers are becoming more conscious of packaging waste.
- Retail partners are beginning to demand more sustainable alternatives.
- Investors have raised concerns regarding the long-term sustainability of the company's packaging model.

A recent sustainability review has concluded that packaging-related impacts represent one of the most significant environmental challenges within SnackCo's value chain.

The Board has requested a strategic recommendation before approving any major packaging transition.

The Challenge

- The CEO wants action.
- The CFO wants profitability.
- The Operations Team wants simplicity.
- The Sustainability Team wants meaningful impact.

Unfortunately, all four cannot be optimized simultaneously.

Your task is to evaluate the problem and recommend a realistic path forward.

Your Assignment

You have been appointed as a Sustainability Consultant advising SnackCo's executive leadership team.

Prepare a professional Executive Memo addressing the following three questions.

Section 1: Identify the Environmental Hotspot

Analyze SnackCo's packaging system and identify the single most significant environmental hotspot.

Examples may include:

- Single-use plastic dependence
- Packaging waste generation
- End-of-life disposal challenges
- Low recycling rates
- Resource-intensive packaging production

You are not required to calculate emissions.

Instead, focus on identifying the stage of the packaging lifecycle creating the greatest sustainability concern and justify your reasoning.

Key Question

Where is the biggest sustainability problem occurring, and why?

Section 2: Design a Circular Economy Intervention

The executive team is specifically interested in moving beyond recycling.

Your task is to propose a Circular Economy intervention based on the principle of:

REUSE

Examples could include:

- Refillable packaging systems
- Deposit-return schemes
- Reusable delivery containers
- Reverse logistics models
- Packaging take-back programs

You may propose any reuse-based solution you believe is appropriate.

Key Question

How can SnackCo reduce packaging waste by keeping materials in use for longer rather than continuously producing new packaging?

Section 3: Define the Trade-Off

Every sustainability intervention creates trade-offs.

The CFO has made it clear:

"If sustainability requires sacrifices, I want to know exactly what we are sacrificing."

Your task is to identify at least one major trade-off that SnackCo must accept in order to implement your proposed solution.

Potential trade-offs may involve:

- Higher packaging costs
- Increased operational complexity
- Slower logistics
- Higher working capital requirements
- Reduced short-term profitability
- Customer adoption challenges

Key Question

What business metric becomes worse in exchange for improved sustainability performance?

Expected Structure

Executive Summary

(Brief overview of your findings and recommendation)

Part 1: Environmental Hotspot Analysis

(Identify and justify the key environmental issue)

Part 2: Circular Reuse Solution

(Describe the proposed intervention)

Part 3: Trade-Off Assessment

(Explain the cost of implementing the solution)

Final Recommendation

(What should SnackCo do and why?)

Evaluation Criteria

Problem Identification - 25%

Ability to identify the most important sustainability issue.

Circular Thinking - 30%

Quality and practicality of the reuse-based intervention.

Trade-Off Analysis - 25%

Ability to recognize operational and financial consequences.

Executive Communication - 20%

Clarity, structure, and persuasiveness of the memo.

Analyst Note

Weak sustainability recommendations focus only on environmental benefits.

Strong sustainability recommendations acknowledge reality:

Every meaningful sustainability decision requires a trade-off.

Your job is not to eliminate trade-offs.

Your job is to identify them, evaluate them, and recommend the option that creates the greatest long-term value for the business.